

Fundamentals of Humanitarian Action *Learning Programme*

Module 1 Workbook: **UNICEF and humanitarian action**

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What is in this workbook?

This workbook looks in general at what UNICEF does in humanitarian action, with a focus on humanitarian emergencies. It covers:

- how UNICEF's mandate relates to humanitarian action
- the importance of linking humanitarian and development work
- how the Convention on the Rights of the Child and the Core Commitments for Children apply in a humanitarian response
- what organisations and groups may work alongside UNICEF during a humanitarian response.

What do you do with this workbook?

The aim of this workbook is to give you a brief explanation of the factors which guide UNICEF's work during a humanitarian emergency. It also introduces some key relevant reference documents so that you can explore the subject further.

This is not a document to just read: you are expected to think carefully about what it says as you go through it and complete some short activities.

'Reflection points' ask you to reflect on your own experience. It will help your understanding and learning if you make notes about these reflections. Sometimes you are asked to do this in the workbook, and sometimes you are asked to write something in an Agora forum. When you write in a forum other people can see what you write, but you can see other people's ideas as well. This will really help everyone to understand more about the topics and issues.

'Do you know ...?' points are questions for you to try and answer. You will find answers for these questions at the end of the workbook.

If you are reading this workbook as part of your preparation for taking part in a workshop on humanitarian action or because you are helping to develop a preparedness plan, you are strongly recommended to discuss your thoughts and ideas with colleagues. This will help you all to deepen your understanding of the subject and to then get more out of working together.

UNICEF's work in humanitarian emergencies

One of the central mandates of the United Nations' system is the "... promotion of higher standards of living, full employment, and conditions of economic and social progress and development."¹ UNICEF's own mandate is: "to advocate for the protection of children's rights, to help meet their basic needs and to expand their opportunities to reach their full potential..."²

These mandates imply timescales of years or decades within which humanitarian crises may occur. This implies that development programming and humanitarian action are not separate activities. Rather, humanitarian action aims not only to protect the rights of affected populations but to promote resilient development, so that communities are better

¹ From: http://www.un.org/esa/about_esa.html

² From: http://www.unicef.org/about/who/index_mission.html

prepared for crises, can manage them better if and when they come and can recover from them more rapidly.

It is therefore important that we see development and humanitarian programming, however they are defined, as activities on a shared continuum.

 Do you know (1)?

The amount of funding which UNICEF spends on humanitarian programming has increased in recent years. By how much do you think it increased between 2011 and 2015?

- A. 10%. B. 40%. C. 70%. D. 120%.

You will find the answer to this question [at the end of the workbook](#).

Some definitions

Here are some explanations for a few terms that are used throughout this learning programme. Note that you will find a more comprehensive set of definitions in the “Reference Document for Emergency Preparedness and Response”.

Emergency: “... a situation that threatens the lives and well-being of large numbers of a population and requires extraordinary action to ensure their survival, care and protection.”³
This loose definition can cover many different types of situation, including natural disasters (earthquakes or climate-related events, for example) or conflict.

Humanitarian situation: “... any circumstance where humanitarian needs are sufficiently large and complex to require significant external assistance and resources, and where a multi-sectoral response is needed, with the engagement of a wide range of international humanitarian actors.”⁴

Humanitarian action: encompasses both interventions focused on preparedness for response to save lives and protect rights as defined in the Core Commitments for Children in Humanitarian Action (CCCs) in line with international standards and guided by humanitarian principles, as well as UNICEF contributions to address underlying causes of vulnerability to disasters, fragility and conflict through both its support in response to humanitarian crises, as well as through its development programming.

As discussed above, humanitarian and development programming should be linked, and not be seen as independent. While humanitarian assistance may need to be provided quickly and to give short-term help, it should where possible integrate with longer-term development aims and goals including to strengthen resilience to shocks and stresses. Examples may include a humanitarian response that is informed by an existing disaster risk analysis, that promotes the role of women as set out in national development plans and that strengthens the capacity of civil society.

This connection between development and humanitarian assistance was stressed as an outcome of the 2016 World Humanitarian Summit, which pointed out the need to adopt

³ From the Glossary, Programme Policy and Procedure Manual, 2009

⁴ IASC Guidance Note, 24.11.2006, and also used in the Core Commitments to Children in Humanitarian Action, 2010

more joined-up approaches to humanitarian and development actions, such as strengthening early warning systems and disaster risk reduction measures⁵.

A key strategy adopted by UNICEF is risk informed programming. This is development programming that is based on an analysis of risks faced by children in the context of shocks and stresses including natural hazards, climate change, conflict and epidemics.

By reducing vulnerability and strengthening the capacities of children, communities and systems, UNICEF supported programming helps to prevent and mitigate risk and prepare for crisis and thus strengthen community resilience to shocks and stresses. Preparedness is one of the pillars of risk informed programming and while Module 5 of this learning programme, “UNICEF emergency preparedness”, looks at this in more detail, more information on humanitarian – development linkages and UNICEF’s draft Guidance on Risk Informed Programming (GRIP) and other resources are available on UNICEF’s ‘Risk, Resilience, Fragility and Peacebuilding’ [Sharepoint](#).



Workbook Forum activity

Before moving on think about the differences and connections between development programming and humanitarian action.

Think about your own experiences. If you have worked in humanitarian situations, think about how well the response linked in with longer-term development goals. What challenges were there to doing this?

If your work is primarily in development programming, think about how well this contributes to resilience and your community’s ability to cope with some form of emergency.

To complete this activity, please record your thoughts in the [dedicated](#) forum on the Module 1 home page within Agora.

UNICEF and the Convention on the Rights of the Child

We looked in the previous section at the wording of UNICEF’s mandate, and this is given real substance by the Convention on the Rights of the Child (CRC)⁶ which is the fundamental driver behind the work that we in UNICEF do.

The CRC is one of the key global human rights instruments which has its roots in the Universal Declaration of Human Rights of 1948⁷. This defines several rights which are particularly important in humanitarian emergencies. These include:

- the right to life, liberty and security
- freedom from interference with privacy, the family or home
- freedom of movement and the right to leave or return to one’s home country
- freedom of thought, conscience, religion, opinion, expression and assembly
- the right to an adequate standard of living, including food, clothing, housing and medical care.

The CRC builds on the Universal Declaration, relating these rights to the particular situation of children. Its four key principles are:

- No child should be discriminated against.

⁵ For more information, see Core Responsibility 4, Commitments to Action, WHS, 2016

⁶ See: <https://www.unicef.org/crc/>

⁷ For a full statement, see <http://www.un.org/en/universal-declaration-human-rights/>

- Acting in the child's best interests.
- Children's rights to survival and development
- Respect for the views of the child.

The Convention puts special emphasis on the need to protect children's rights as early as possible in their lives.

The CRC came into force in 1990, once it had been ratified by a required number of states. 196 countries have currently ratified it, and this includes every member of the United Nations except the United States.

There are also three optional protocols:

- Optional Protocol on the Involvement of Children in Armed Conflict (2002), which restricts the involvement of children in military conflicts.
- Optional Protocol on the Sale of Children, Child Prostitution and Child Pornography (2002), which prohibits these activities.
- Optional Protocol to the Convention on the Rights of the Child on a Communications Procedure (2014), which allows children or their representatives to file complaints about rights violations.



Reflection point

Read through the Universal Declaration of Human Rights (<http://www.un.org/en/universal-declaration-human-rights/>). Compare this with the summary of the Convention on the Rights of the Child below. See if you can identify which general statements have equivalents in the CRC so that you understand the connection between the two documents. Make a note of what you discover in the box provided.

This exercise will help you to develop a deeper understanding of how UNICEF's work is closely connected with the broader concept of human rights.

Although there are strong connections between all the articles within the CRC (and you should certainly have read the entire document and be familiar with its provisions), it is useful to look at certain articles which can have a particular relevance to humanitarian action.

Article 2 states that there should be no discrimination against any child on the basis of their or their parent or guardian's "... race, colour, sex, language, religion, political or other opinion,

national, ethnic or social origin, property, disability, birth or other status”⁸. Children’s abilities to enjoy this right can be affected during emergencies, particularly within civil conflicts, which are often based around some form of discrimination.

Article 3 states that decisions about a child’s welfare should see the “best interests of the child” as the primary consideration. This relies on functional institutions and laws within a country, which of course during an emergency may be less effective. Supporting such institutions during a humanitarian situation can be a vital role for UNICEF, and the humanitarian community must consider this as one of its overriding principles when designing and delivering programmes.

Article 6 states that every child has an inherent right to life, and that States must do what they can to ensure every child’s survival and development. Humanitarian emergencies can, of course, place great strain on a State’s ability to do this, and UNICEF may play an important role in ensuring that this right is respected.

Article 12 states that every child capable of expressing their own views has the right to be able to do so. This means that the views of children need to be taken into consideration during the planning and delivery of a humanitarian response, and that this must always inform best interest determinations which need to be made. This clearly has connections with Article 3.

Article 22 concerns refugee children, and confirms that they must be as equally protected as are adults under the different laws relating to asylum and refugee status.

Article 38 covers the involvement of children affected by conflict and must be considered alongside the optional protocol, the Paris Principles, and the various Security Council resolutions relating to the Monitoring and Reporting Mechanism for Grave Child Rights Violations (MRM GCRV).

Finally, **Article 45** refers explicitly to UNICEF and its role in helping States to fulfil their responsibilities under the Convention.

The Core Commitments for Children in Humanitarian Action

While the Convention on the Rights of the Child provides a foundation for UNICEF’s work globally, what it means in practice in a humanitarian response is described within the “Core Commitments for Children in Humanitarian Action” of 2010⁹.

An essential part of your study in this learning programme is to carefully read the Core Commitments, and you are asked to do this in another part of this module. You also should have completed the CCC on-line course.

There are three sections in the Core Commitments: essential humanitarian principles and some operational frameworks, programme commitments and associated operational commitments.

Humanitarian principles, which include humanity, neutrality, impartiality and independence, form the starting point for all humanitarian action. These principles are closely connected to the human rights defined in the 1948 Universal Declaration, and this has led to the ‘rights-based approach’ which is a fundamental idea within the Core Commitments. You will sometimes see this referred to as HRBAP, or the ‘human rights-based approach to programming’. You will find more information about humanitarian principles in Module 2.

⁸ See: <http://www.ohchr.org/EN/ProfessionalInterest/Pages/CRC.aspx>

⁹ See: https://www.unicef.org/publications/files/CCC_042010.pdf

Programme commitments are actions specific to UNICEF's sectoral activities, such as nutrition, health, WASH, child protection, education, HIV and AIDS, and supply. They draw from and are consistent with the global humanitarian standards with which you may be familiar, such as the International Network for Education in Emergencies (INEE), the Minimum Standards for Child Protection in Humanitarian Settings, the Core Humanitarian Standard and Sphere. These are all discussed in more detail in Module 3.

You also need to be aware of areas of UNICEF's work which cut across the sectors covered in the CCC, such as Early Childhood Development (ECD), Adolescence Development, Advocacy, Communication for Development (C4D). What programming actions are relevant depends on the operational context: are we looking at being prepared for a humanitarian emergency, responding to one, in a protracted crisis or are moving back to a more stable situation. In the commitments you will find that actions are listed under three different headings, preparedness, response and early recovery.

We have learnt however from the changing nature of humanitarian crisis and the international community's experience since 2010, that emergencies don't always neatly fit into "preparedness", "response" and "early recovery" phases or categories particularly in protracted crisis or countries in fragile situations and the approach to viewing humanitarian and development work is to link planning and activities more closely together. Therefore, while the defined actions in the CCCs remain relevant, preparedness should be considered not only as required prior to response, but as an ongoing dynamic process, and early recovery is more often seen as an approach taken at the same time during the response as opposed as something separately happening afterwards.

What programming actions are relevant depends on the operational context: are we looking at being prepared for a humanitarian emergency, responding to one, in a protracted crisis or are moving back to a more stable situation (perhaps a more 'development programming' context)? So, in the commitments you will find that actions are listed under three different headings, preparedness, response and early recovery.

Look at these examples of actions taken from the child protection sector:

- Preparedness: "Clarify the responsibilities of UNICEF and its partners regarding child protection in humanitarian situations."
- Response: "Advocate immediately for family-based care for separated children, and work to prevent separation during displacement and extreme economic hardship."
- Early recovery: "Support partners in identifying, monitoring, and reporting on serious protection concerns to trigger response and advocacy."

Operational commitments are the activities which support the sectors. These cover media and communications, security, human resources, resource mobilisation, finance and administration and information and communication technology.

As with programme commitments, these actions also reflect preparedness, response, and early recovery.

An example of a preparedness operational commitment (for media and communications activities) is to "Ensure that a communications strategy is part of preparedness planning".

For the strategic results in both the programme and operational commitments, Commitment 1 is about coordination and working with partners. Because of its technical expertise, UNICEF usually has the responsibility for coordination and promoting inter-agency working in all areas related to children's survival and well-being.

? Do you know (2)?

Just to make sure you understand the difference between programme and operational commitments, read through this list of commitments and, for each, decide if it is a programme or an operational commitment.

Commitment	Programme commitment	Operational commitment
The situation of children and women is monitored and sufficiently analysed, and rapid assessments are carried out whenever necessary.	☐	☐
Security risks that could affect staff and assets, and subsequently the emergency response, are identified, assessed and managed.	☐	☐
Well-being of staff is assured.	☐	☐
Children, adolescents and women equitably access essential health services with sustained coverage of high-impact preventive and curative interventions.	☐	☐

You will find the answers to this question [at the end of the workbook](#).

Who is involved in humanitarian action?

UNICEF may be working with many different actors in a humanitarian response. You may be familiar with some of these from working in a development programming context, while others may be unfamiliar. However, even if you are familiar with an actor working in development, you may find that their role is a little different when in a humanitarian emergency.

It will be useful to list these actors here as they are referred to throughout the programme. You will find more information about how the actors work together in an actual humanitarian emergency response in Module 4.

The affected population

The local population, effectively the people directly affected by the emergency, are obviously the most essential actors to consider during a response and there is a need to ensure they are at the centre of decision-making and response efforts. After all, the primary aim of humanitarian action is to protect them and their rights, and local populations are often the first responders and remain to both look after themselves and others, long after most international actors have come and gone.

At the same time, working effectively with the local population can be challenging in a humanitarian response: people can be homeless or traumatised, they may have had to move to unfamiliar locations, they may be wary of the motives of 'outsiders', and have expectations or needs that may be difficult to meet.

If UNICEF has been working in an area for a long period of time before the emergency, its staff may well have developed relationships with members of the local population and this can be crucial in the event of an emergency.

The host government

The host government in the state where the emergency is happening is central to the response. They have overall responsibility for initiating and implementing the humanitarian response, making sure it is effective, and guiding and coordinating the other humanitarian actors.

Many countries have their own national disaster management agency, but depending on the scale and context of the emergency the government may need support from other actors.

The Humanitarian Country Team

In many of the countries where UNICEF works, if there is or has been an emergency a Humanitarian Country Team (HCT) will be created or will already exist. This team contains representatives from the major international organisations working in the country, which will include the United Nations agencies present, the International Organisation for Migration (IOM), the Red Cross and Red Crescent Movement and international NGOs.

The head of the HCT is the Humanitarian Coordinator (HC), who will normally be the Resident Coordinator (RC) who leads the Country Team on behalf of the Secretary General, double-hatting both positions (called an RC/HC). Alternatively, a separate HC might be appointed, or where a peacekeeping or political mission is present, the RC/HC could be the Deputy Special Representative of the Secretary-General (DSRG) of the mission, triple-hatting these positions.

United Nations agencies

Which United Nations agencies join the HCT will depend on which ones are operational in the country. Depending on the nature of the emergency some agencies will establish an operational presence even if they have not been present before. Agencies such as UNICEF and UNDP which carry out a lot of development programming activities will almost always be present. Other agencies that may often be present in a humanitarian emergency include the Office for the Coordination of Humanitarian Affairs (OCHA), World Health Organisation (WHO), United Nations Population Fund (UNFPA), the World Food Programme (WFP) and the UN High Commissioner for Refugees (UNCHR).

International Red Cross and Red Crescent Movement

The representatives of the Red Cross and Red Crescent Movement are major non-governmental actors working in a humanitarian response. The Movement is made up of three different actors, which each have different responsibilities.

The **International Committee for the Red Cross (ICRC)** is the world's oldest humanitarian organisation, having been established in 1863. It is based in Geneva. Its role is both strategic and operational, as it has the responsibility to liaise directly with governments to make sure the requirements of the various Geneva Conventions are being observed during a conflict, and that civilian populations receive necessary protection and care. It is a private and neutral organisation, and is recognised in international humanitarian law as having a special status for ensuring that these laws are being complied with.

National Red Cross or Red Crescent Societies work at a national level in each country. They work to provide practical support in a wide range of activities to public authorities in the event of an emergency. These activities can include anything from providing first aid to

supplying disaster relief teams. National Society volunteers are often first on the scene in an emergency.

The **International Federation of Red Cross and Red Crescent Societies** (IFRC) is the umbrella body responsible for coordinating the activities of the national societies. It is also based in Geneva. If a humanitarian emergency strikes a country, its own national society may look for help from the IFRC in getting help from other national societies. Societies in countries such as the United States, the United Kingdom, Germany, Sweden and Norway are often involved in humanitarian actions.

Non-Governmental Organisations

The term Non-Governmental Organisation (NGO) covers a very wide range of actors, some large, some small, some international, some national. Most specialise in certain activities or working with groups in society. Some NGOs may shape their activities around a particular faith or set of beliefs: these are sometimes referred to as 'faith-based organisations'.

From your own experience, you will know national NGOs in your country which UNICEF works with, and will also know of the major international NGOs who work with children, such as Save the Children, Plan International, International Rescue Committee (IRC), CARE, World Vision and Oxfam.

Community-based organisations

Community-based organisations (CBOs) are smaller, more locally-based organisations. They may have a formal structure or be quite informal groupings of people sharing an interest in a particular area or neighbourhood. CBOs can sometimes be faith-based.

Although small, CBOs are often the first organisations to respond in the aftermath of an emergency in their area, and being local, they usually have good knowledge about who lives in the area, where things are, and how things work. They are therefore very important organisations to work with in a humanitarian response.

Armed actors

Armed actors or groups are usually defined in two ways – the “military” or “non-state” armed actors.

The term ‘military’ usually refers to:

- the armed forces of the host government
- armed forces of another country, or peacekeeping forces (who could provide or are providing some form of international humanitarian assistance or security).

The term “non-state armed groups” is used to describe those armed groups not part of the government military structure such as local militias or other forms of ‘opposition’ or “rebel” that may be present in a civil conflict.

Military involvement in a humanitarian response can be valuable: military forces often have skills and equipment useful for such things as providing armed escorts, analysis, and information, clearing roads, rebuilding bridges and other infrastructure. However, the principles and operations of armed forces work may conflict with that of humanitarian actors, and of course, the country’s history may affect local people’s perceptions of the neutrality, impartiality, or independence of any military or other armed actor. Military involvement also can have implications for the protection of the affected population.

Principles guiding UNICEF interactions with the military can be found at <http://www.unocha.org/themes/humanitarian-civil-military-coordination>

The private sector

The private sector refers to any relevant commercial activity which happens in the local area or country, and which can play a part in a humanitarian response. For example, local logistics companies may be able to provide vehicles to transport people or relief supplies, and local traders may have supplies of food or other materials which are of use in the response.

It is often preferable to involve local private sector organisations in a humanitarian response rather than to rely on international assistance, as this helps to keep local markets working and allow local communities to be a fundamental part of the response.

Donors

Donors are obviously important because they provide funds and other resources to support a humanitarian response. They may also have staff in place monitoring the response, to make sure that their funds are being used effectively.



Reflection point

Think about this list of organisations or groups who will have some part to play in a humanitarian response. How many people in such organisations do you know? Knowing such people, and even better, having a good working relationship with them, during normal times can make it much easier to collaborate during an emergency.

In the space below make a list of people that you know from the groups mentioned who you would be able to make contact with in the event of an emergency. Make another list of organisations or groups where you do not know anybody but think that it would be useful to do so. This is a really useful activity to do to help you develop your networks so that you can respond more effectively in the event of an emergency.

Summary

Here are the key points from this workbook:

- UNICEF's mandate means that it works in both development and humanitarian contexts, and this gives it a particular advantage in implementing humanitarian responses which link closely with development programming.
- Humanitarian and development programming need to be closely linked to enable communities to be more resilient to the impact of humanitarian crises, for development to be more sustainable and to reduce the magnitude of response required.

- Key documents guiding UNICEF's work in preparing and responding to humanitarian emergencies are the Convention on the Rights of the Child and the Core Commitments for Children in Humanitarian Action.
- Effective humanitarian response requires coordinated action from a wide range of different actors. It is essential to know and build relationships with them prior to an emergency occurring.

Further information

The table below provides links to the various declarations, guidelines and reference materials which have been discussed in this workbook, and adds some others which may be of interest.

Reference material	Internet link
World Humanitarian Summit, 2016, Commitments to Action	http://www.worldhumanitariansummit.org/sites/default/files/media/WHS%20Commitment%20to%20Action_8September2016.pdf
Convention on the Rights of the Child	http://www.ohchr.org/EN/ProfessionalInterest/Pages/CRC.aspx
Core Commitments to Children	http://www.unicefinemergencies.com/downloads/eresource/CCCs.html
Universal Declaration of Human Rights	http://www.un.org/en/universal-declaration-human-rights/
ICRC	https://www.icrc.org/
IFRC	http://www.ifrc.org/

Answers to "Do you know" questions

? Do you know? (1)

The answer is that the amount of money which UNICEF spent on responding to humanitarian crises increased by nearly 70% between 2011 and 2015. This represents a total of \$5.7 billion during this period.

Looking at the wider picture, during the 1970s and 1980s humanitarian activities accounted for about 1 or 2% of total development programming funding, while in 2013 it represented 9.4% of total funding¹⁰. This has primarily been because of the great increase in political instability and civil conflict in many countries around the world since the early 1990s.

? Do you know? (2)

Just to make sure you understand the difference between programme and operational commitments, read through this list of commitments and, for each, decide if it is a programme or an operational commitment.

Commitment	Programme commitment	Operational commitment
The situation of children and women is monitored and sufficiently analysed, and rapid assessments are carried out whenever necessary.	☒	☐
Security risks that could affect staff and assets, and subsequently the emergency response, are identified, assessed and managed.	☐	☒
Well-being of staff is assured.	☐	☒
Children, adolescents and women equitably access essential health services with sustained coverage of high-impact preventive and curative interventions.	☒	☐

The first and fourth commitments here are programme commitments (Rapid assessment Commitment 1 and Health Commitment 3 respectively), while the second and third are operational commitments (Security Commitment 1 and Human resources Commitment 2 respectively).

¹⁰ Source: <http://www.oecd.org/dac/stats/aid-at-a-glance.htm>